

Nigeria–New Zealand International Migration

Publication-ready statistical report: Nigeria versus West Africa, Africa and the World
2001–March 2026

Executive conclusion. Nigeria is the dominant West African source of long-term migrant arrivals to New Zealand in this dataset. It accounts for approximately 54.4% of cumulative West African arrivals, ranks sixth in Africa over the full period, but rises to third in Africa in each of 2023–2025. The post-2022 level is materially higher than the historical pre-2020 pattern.

Metric	Nigeria	West Africa	Africa	World
Cumulative 2001–Mar 2026	1,892	3,477	142,754	3,107,472
Nigeria share	—	54.4%	1.33%	0.061%
2025 arrivals	207	287	3,525	131,960
Nigeria rank	—	1st	3rd in 2025	~51st in 2025

1. Data and methodology

The supplied CSV contains 364,350 rows covering long-term migrant arrivals. The analysis uses the canonical TOTAL citizenship × TOTAL visa series by country of last permanent residence to avoid double-counting visa and citizenship subtotals. Annual inferential analysis uses complete years 2001–2025. January–March 2026 is reported separately because the source ends in March 2026.

Stats NZ defines international migration using an outcomes-based measure derived from travel histories and a 12/16-month rule; the series is available back to January 2001. Recent observations are provisional and can be revised because final classification requires up to 16 months of travel history.

Geographical definitions

West Africa is defined for this report as Benin, Burkina Faso, Cabo Verde, Côte d'Ivoire, Gambia, Ghana, Guinea, Guinea-Bissau, Liberia, Mali, Mauritania, Niger, Nigeria, Senegal, Sierra Leone and Togo, restricted to country names actually present in the file. Africa uses the corresponding African country list present in the file. "World" uses the dataset TOTAL row.

2. Nigeria and regional trajectory

Chart 1. Nigeria long-term migrant arrivals

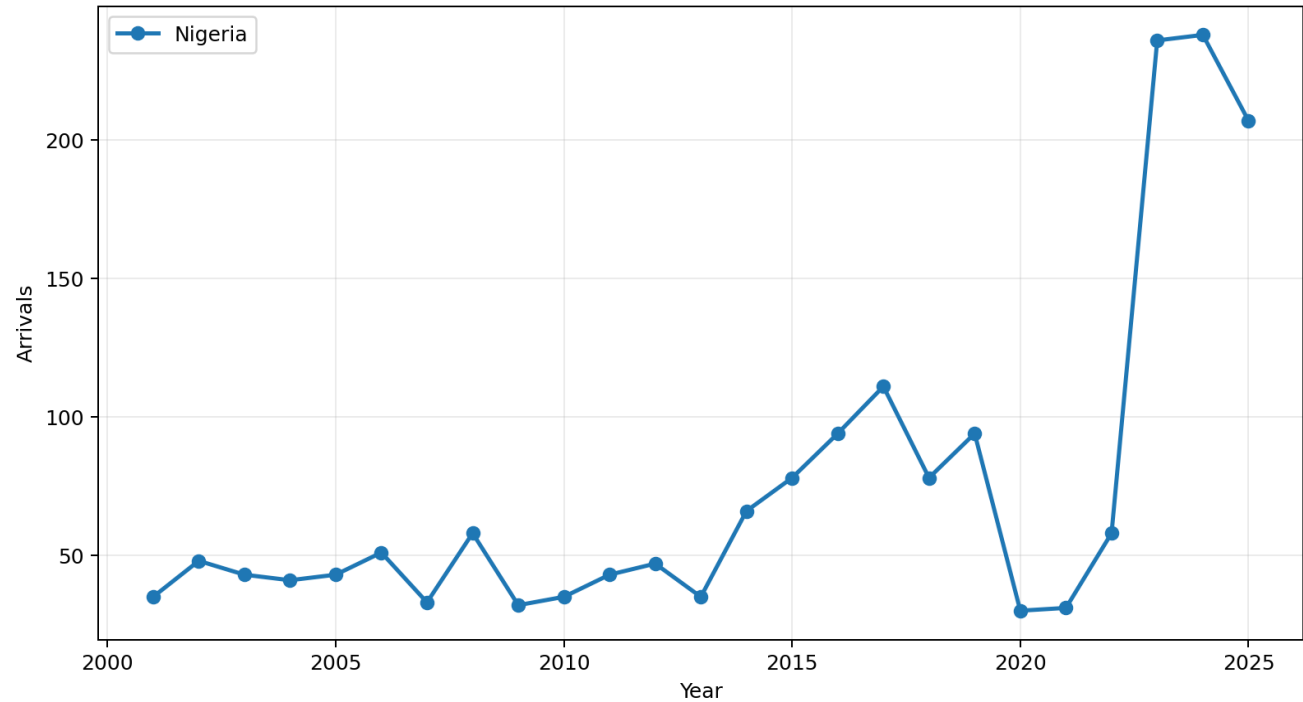


Chart 2. Nigeria versus West Africa

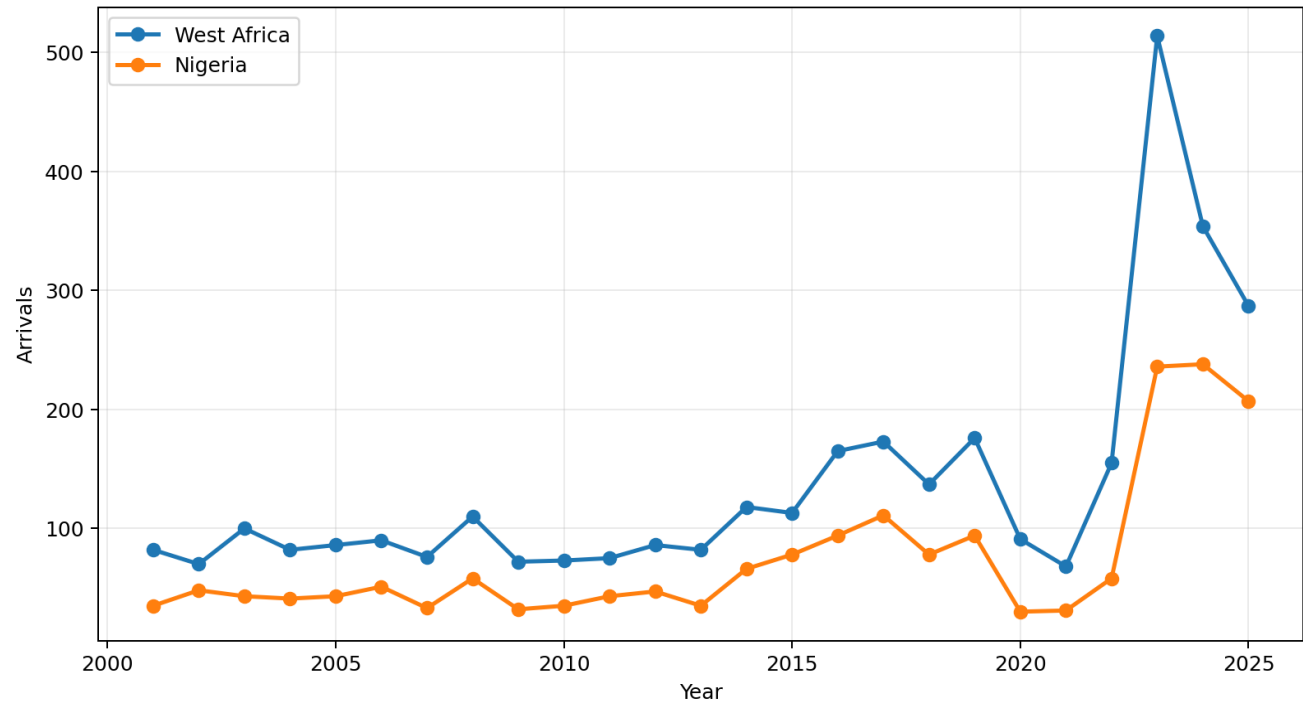


Chart 3. Nigeria versus Africa

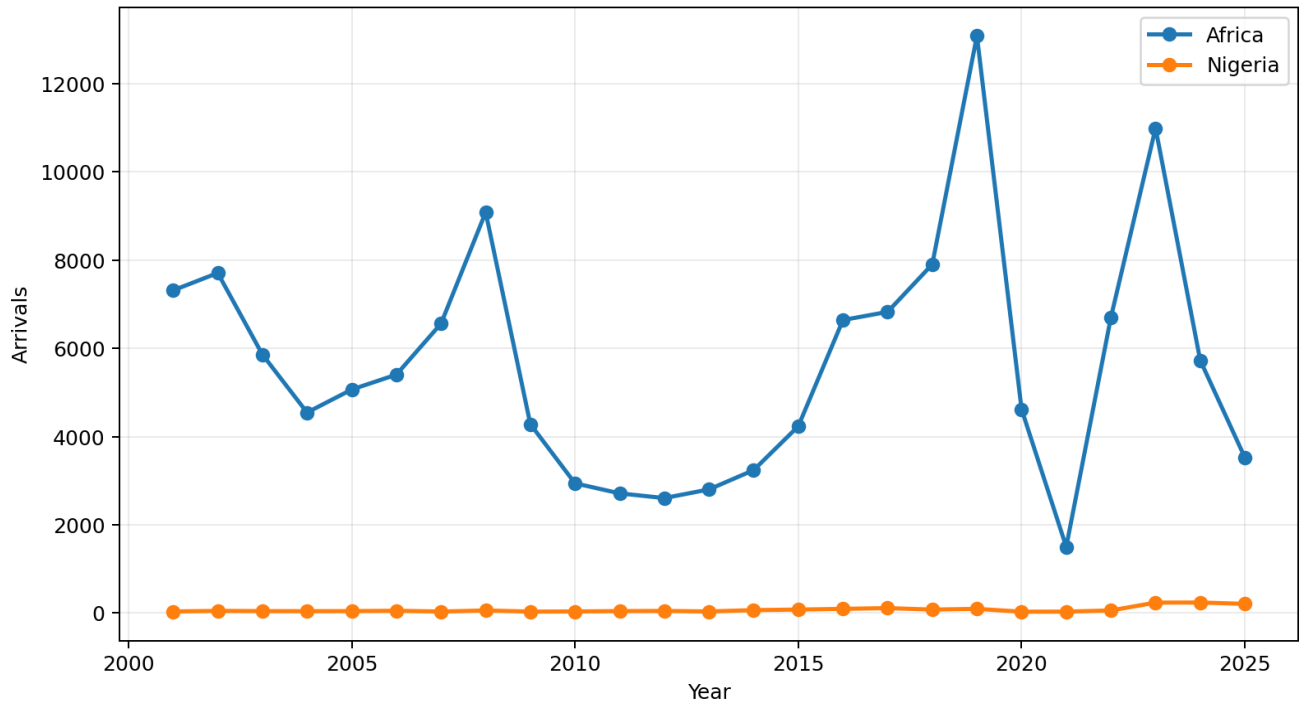


Chart 4. Nigeria versus world

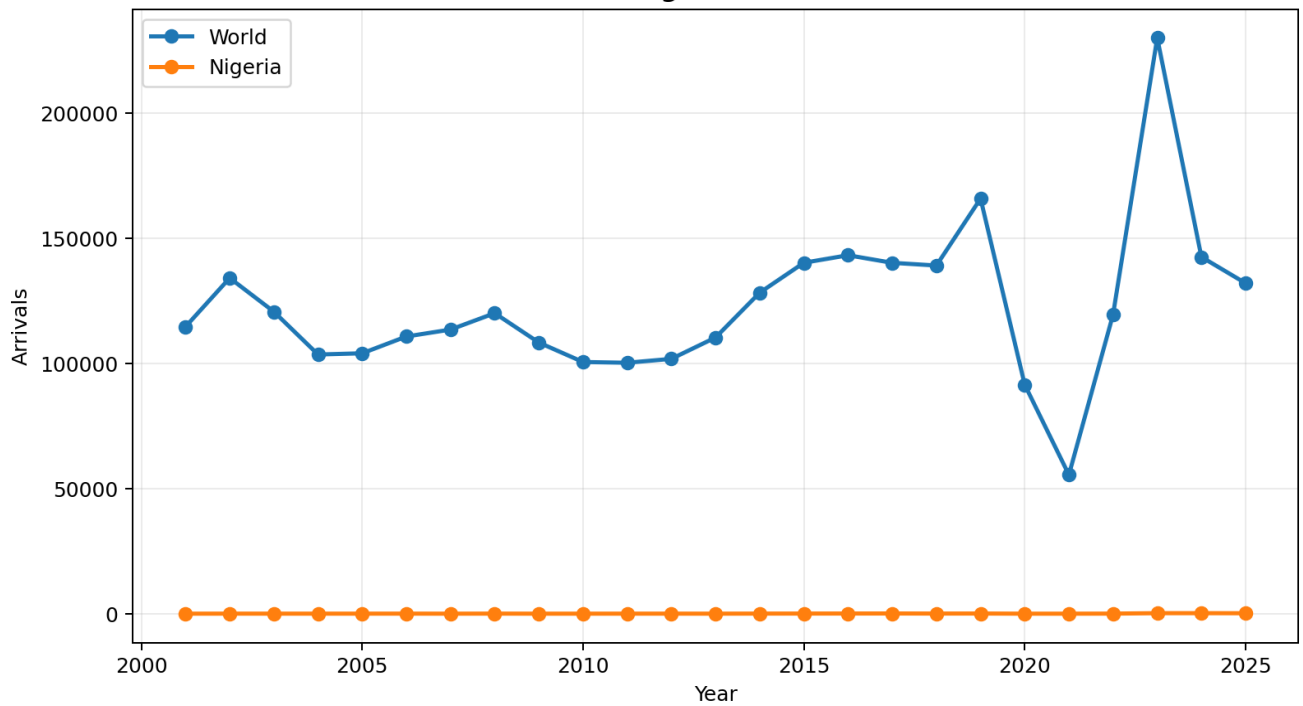


Chart 5. Nigeria versus rest of West Africa

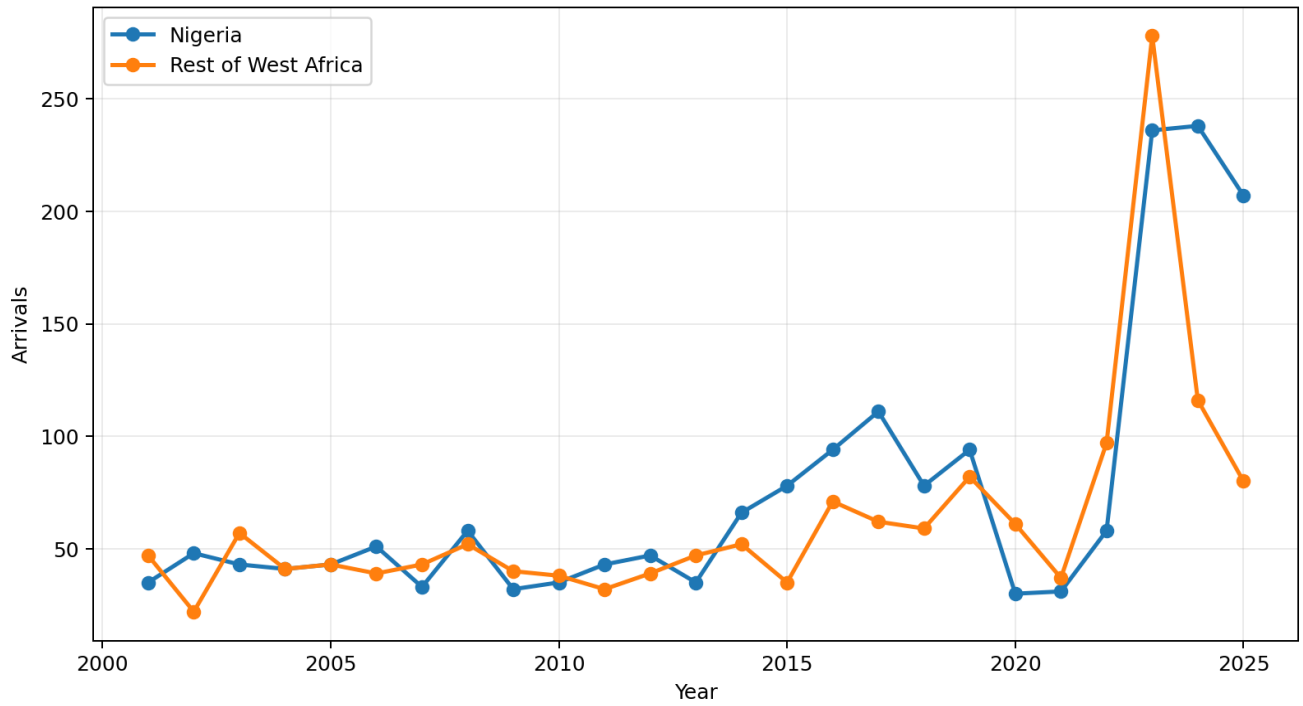
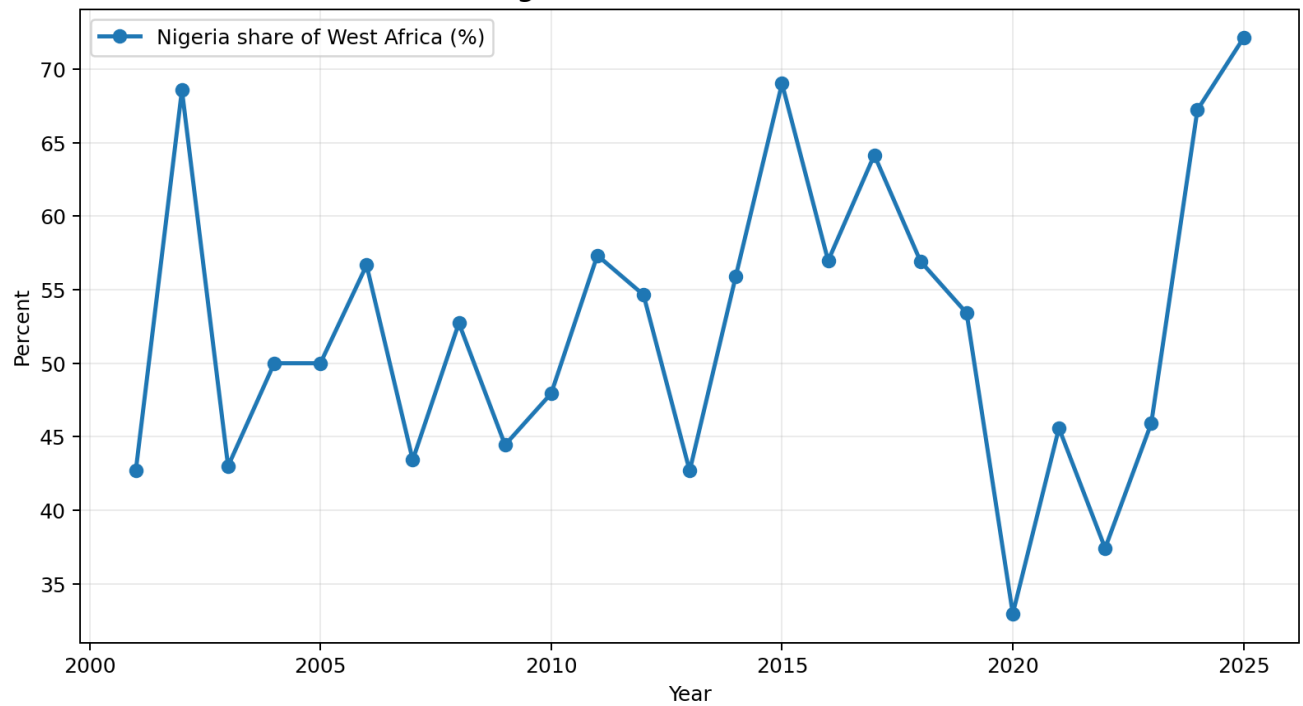


Chart 6. Nigeria share of West African arrivals



3. Africa, global position and rankings

Chart 7. Nigeria versus rest of Africa

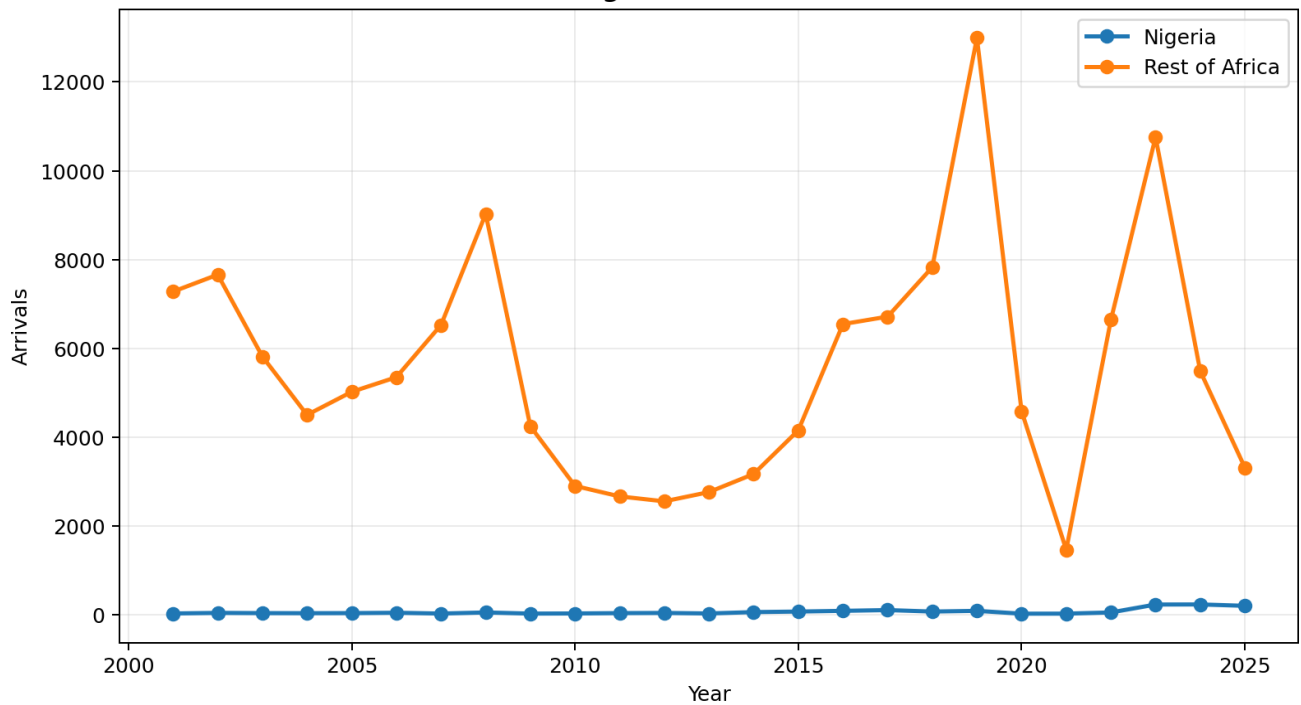


Chart 8. Nigeria share of African arrivals

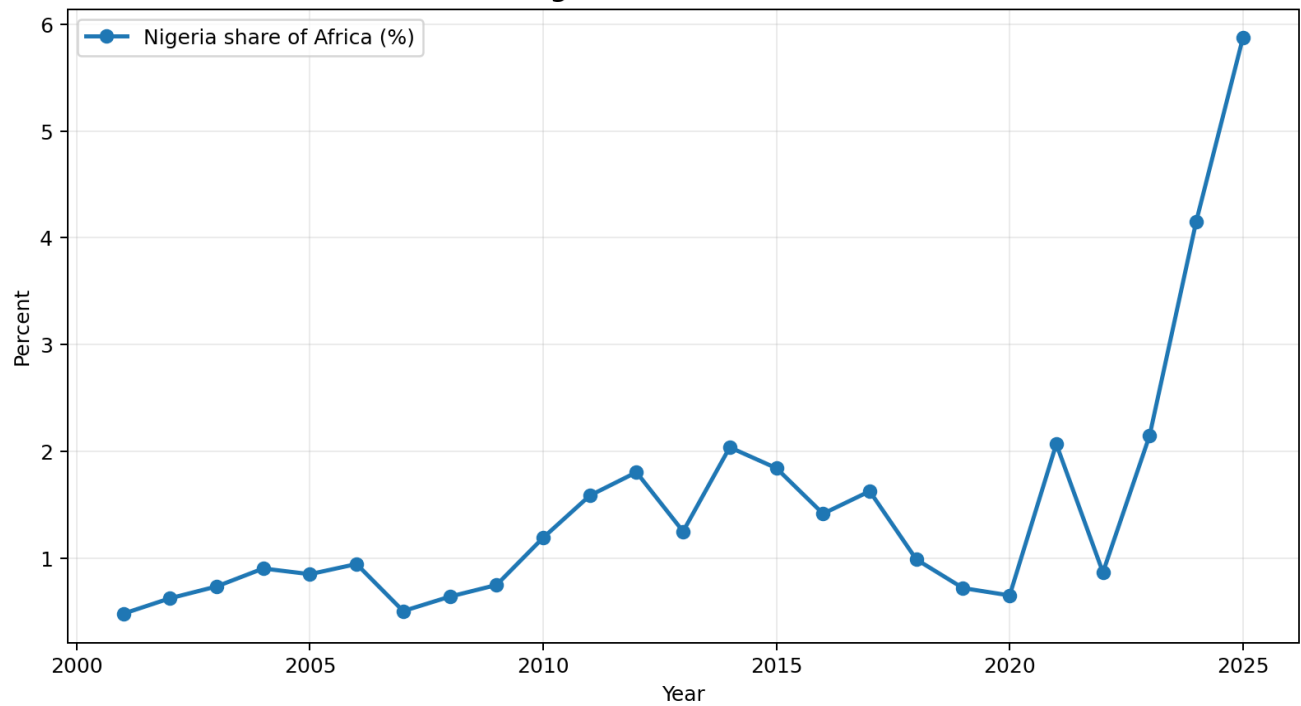


Chart 9. Indexed growth since 2001 (2001=100)

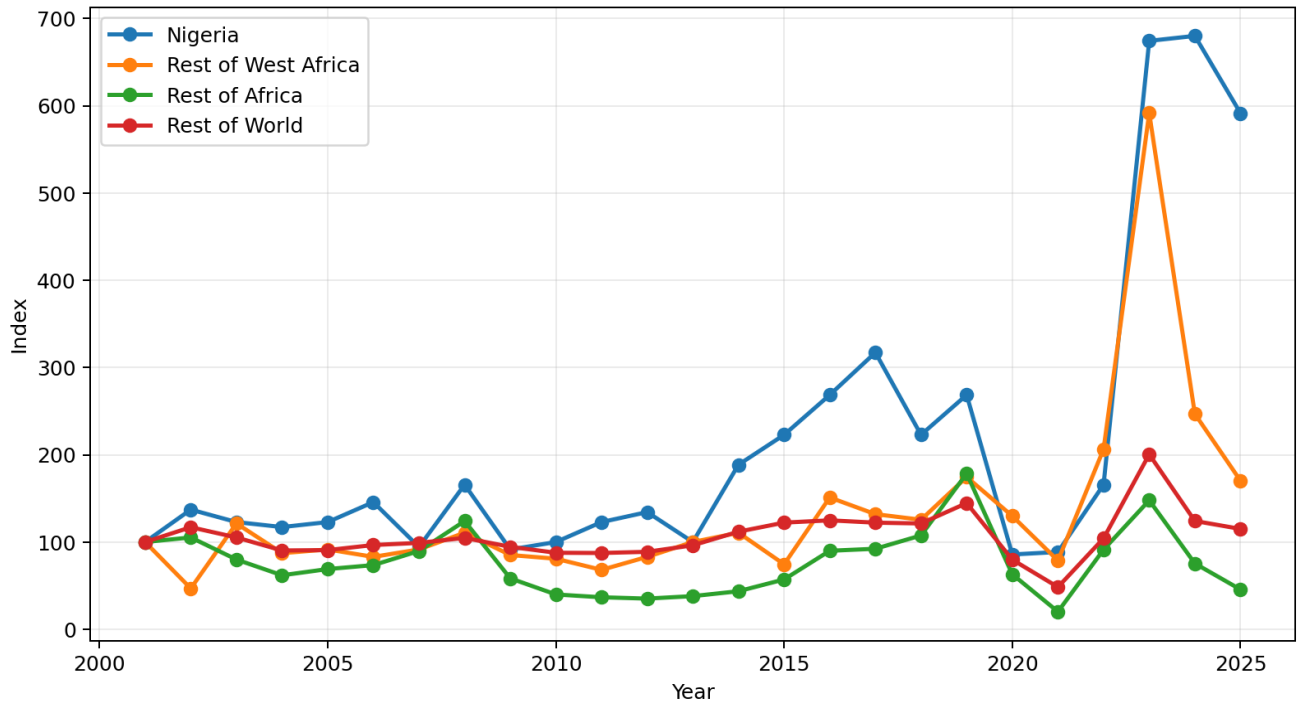


Chart 10. Top African source countries, cumulative 2001-Mar 2026

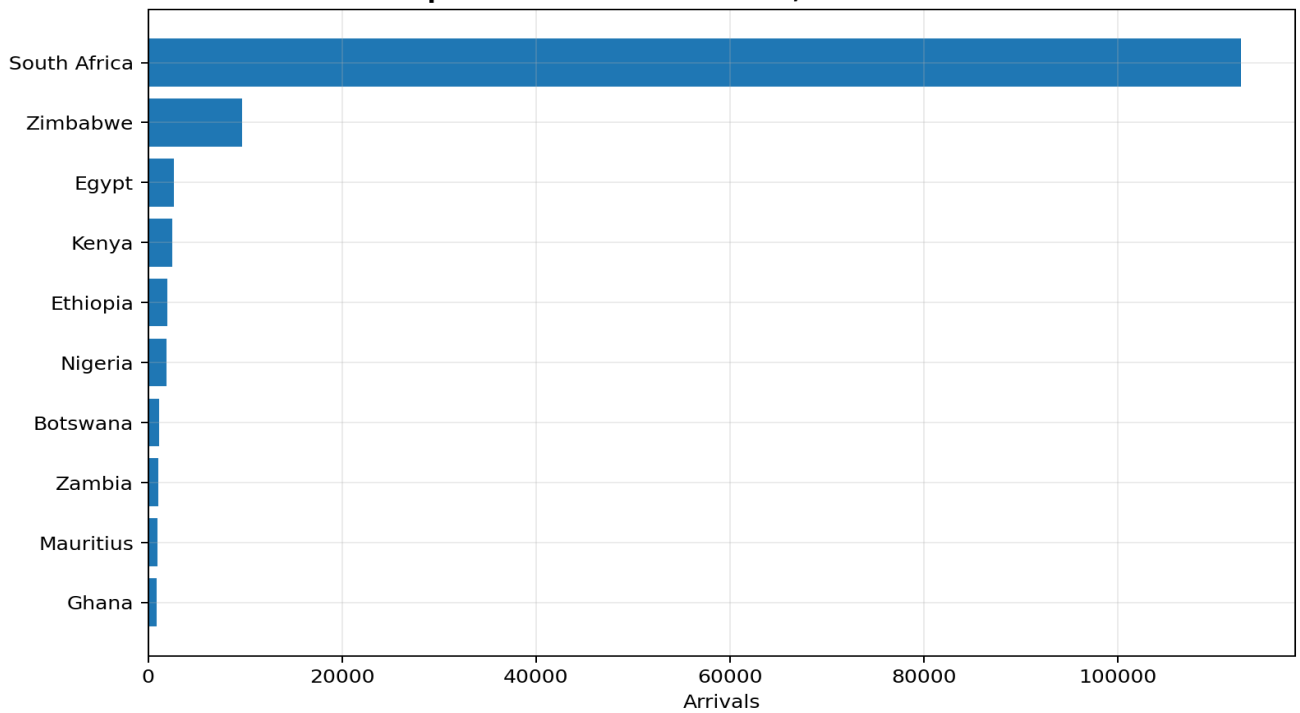


Chart 11. Top West African source countries, cumulative 2001-Mar 2026

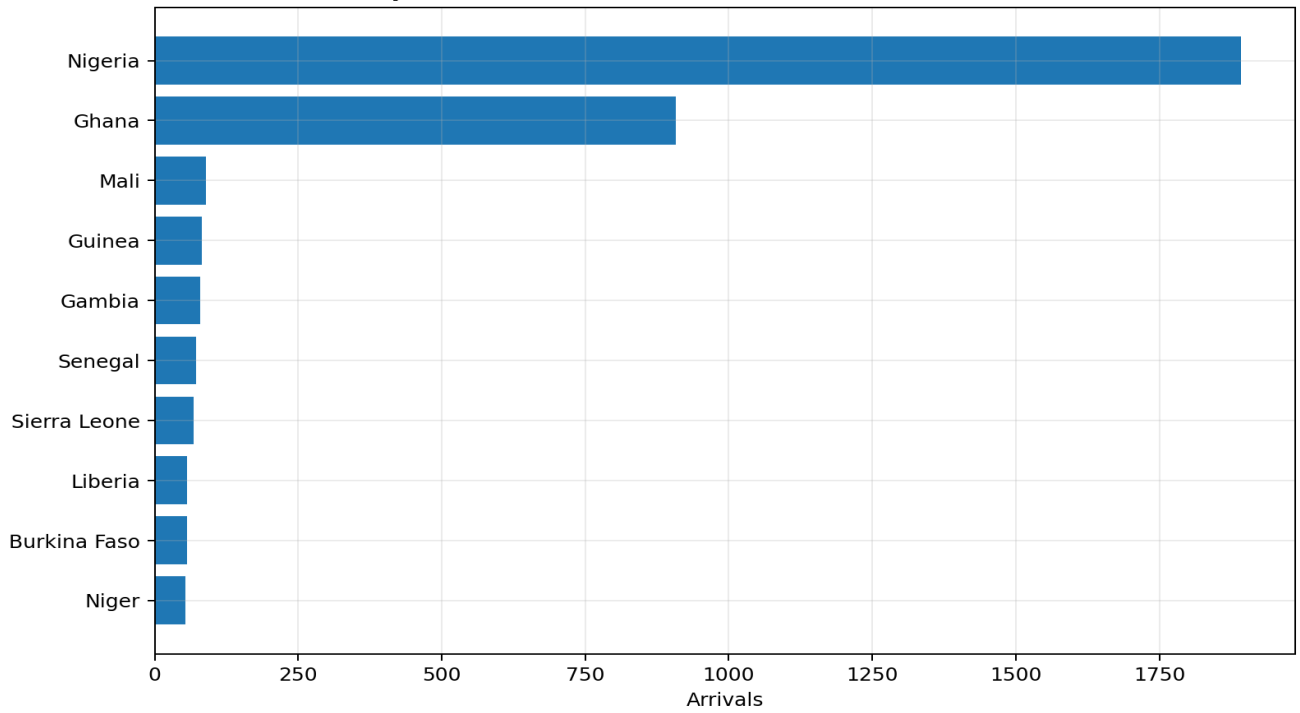
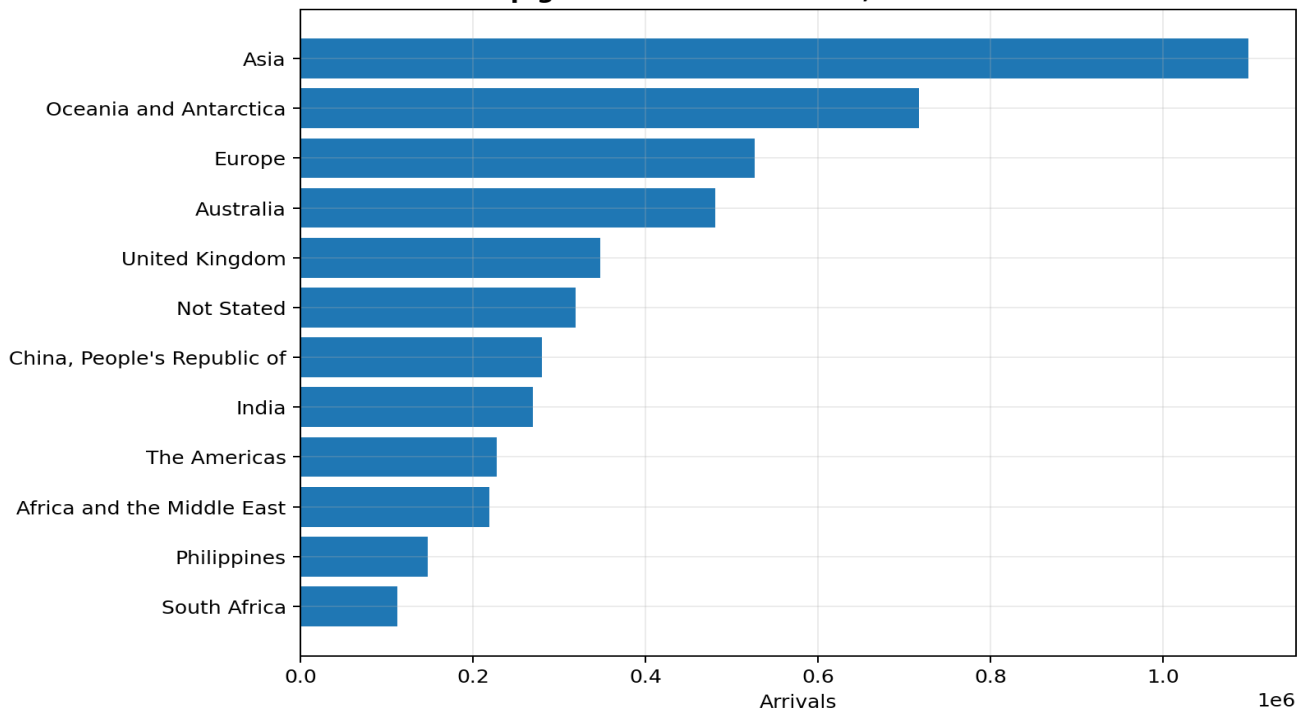


Chart 12. Top global source countries, cumulative 2001-Mar 2026



4. Visa pathway analysis

Chart 13. Nigeria visa composition, cumulative

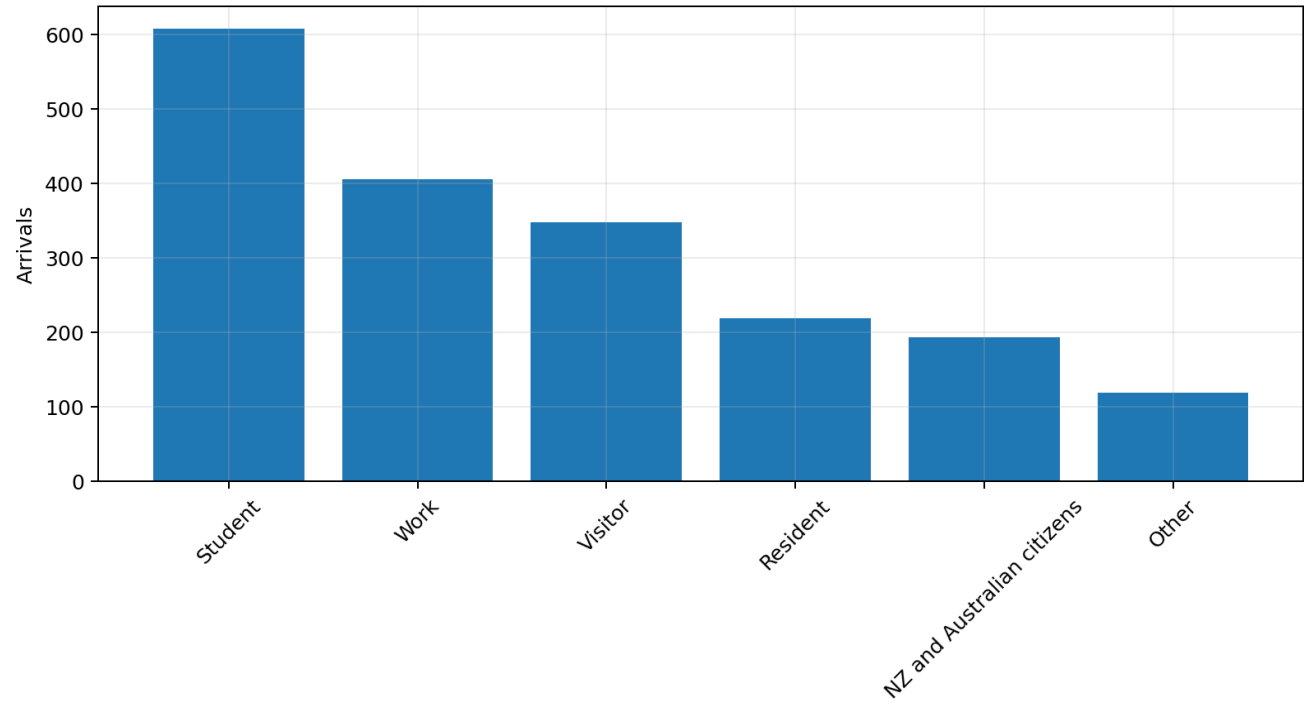


Chart 14. Nigeria visa pathway trends, 2015-2025

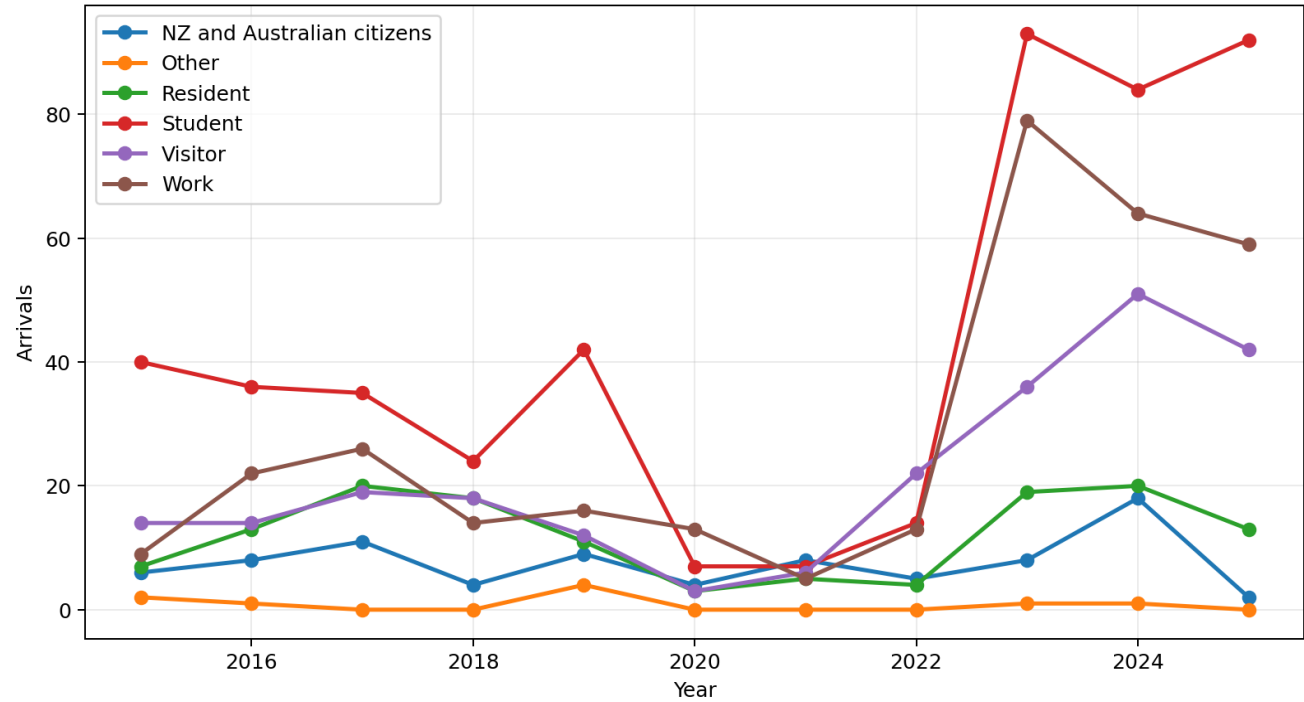


Chart 15. Visa composition in 2025: Nigeria vs rest of West Africa

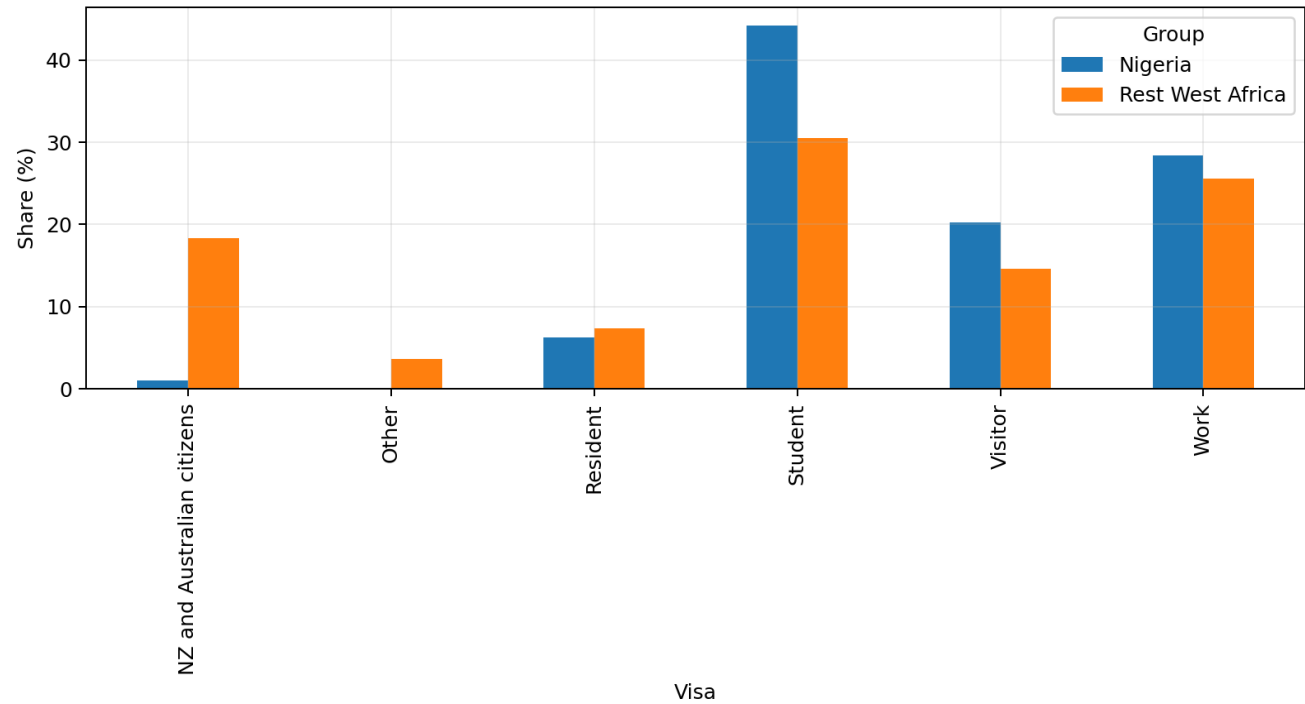
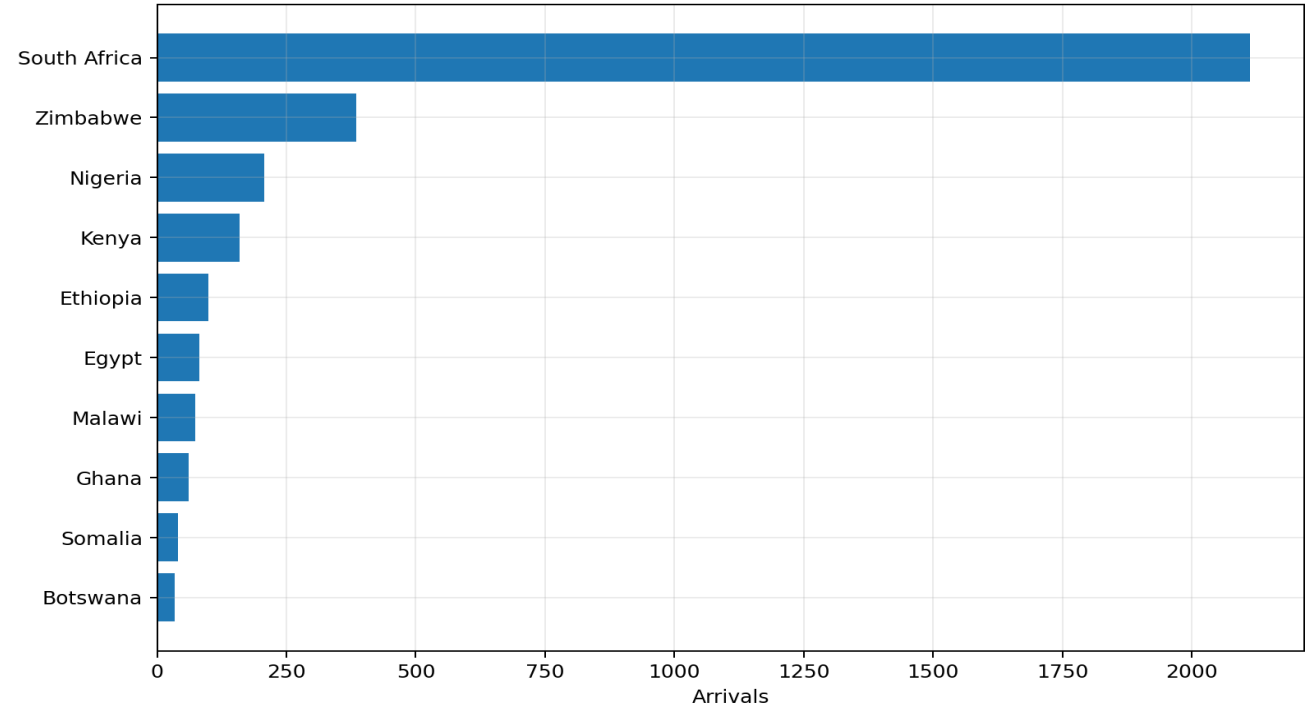


Chart 16. African source countries in 2025



5. Regression, correlation and hypothesis tests

Ordinary least squares regression of annual Nigerian arrivals on year gives a slope of 5.42 arrivals per year (95% CI 2.66 to 8.17), $p=0.0004811$, $R^2=0.418$. This supports a statistically significant positive long-run trend, while the modest R^2 also shows that year alone does not explain the large shocks in the series.

A segmented model adding a post-2022 indicator estimates a post-2022 level shift of 154.5 arrivals ($p=2.24e-09$, $R^2=0.889$), consistent with a major change in the Nigerian series after 2022.

Pearson correlations between Nigeria and the rest of West Africa, rest of Africa and rest of the world are 0.758, 0.308 and 0.718, respectively; all are statistically significant at conventional levels. These are associations, not causal effects.

Welch two-sample test comparing 2001–2019 with 2023–2025 gives $t=-14.96$, $p=0.0003483$; the non-parametric Mann–Whitney test gives $U=0.0$, $p=0.007222$. Both indicate that the recent Nigerian annual distribution is materially higher than the pre-COVID period.

A chi-square test of visa composition for Nigeria versus the rest of West Africa over 2023–2025 gives $\chi^2=62.16$, $df=5$, $p=4.355e-12$, indicating a statistically detectable difference in pathway composition.

Chart 17. Nigeria trend regression, 2001–2025

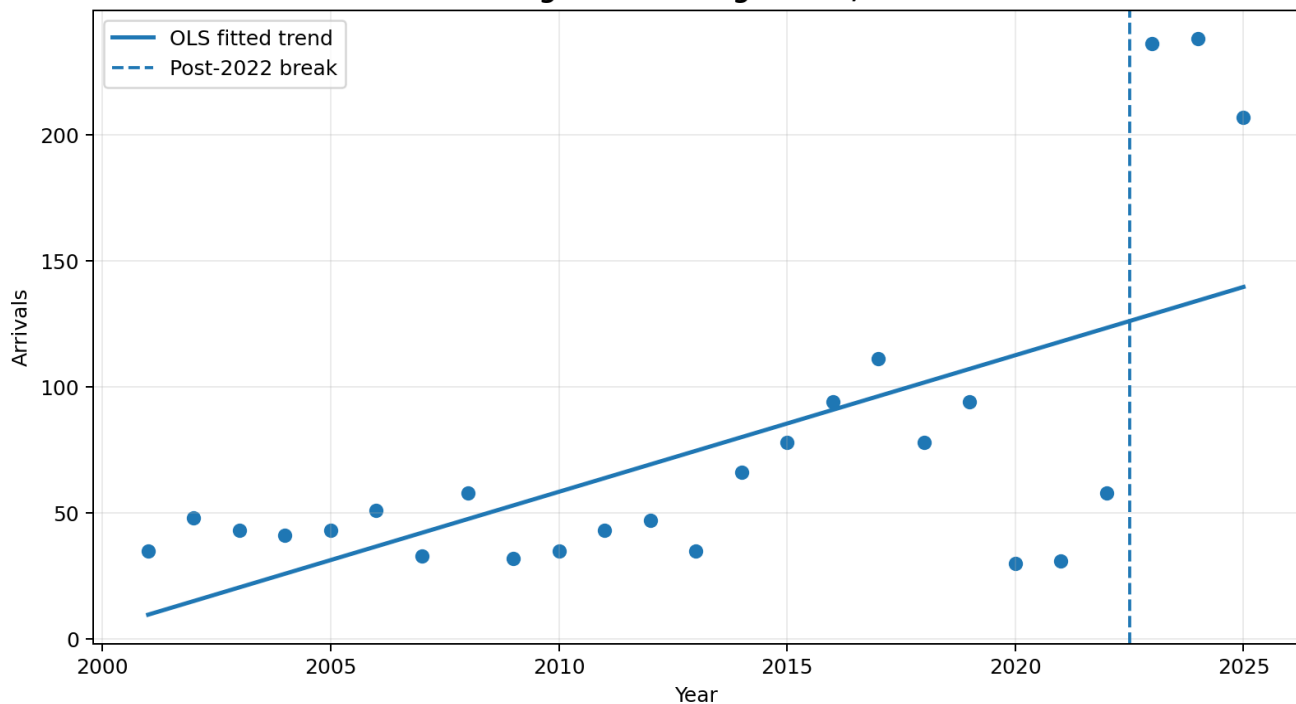
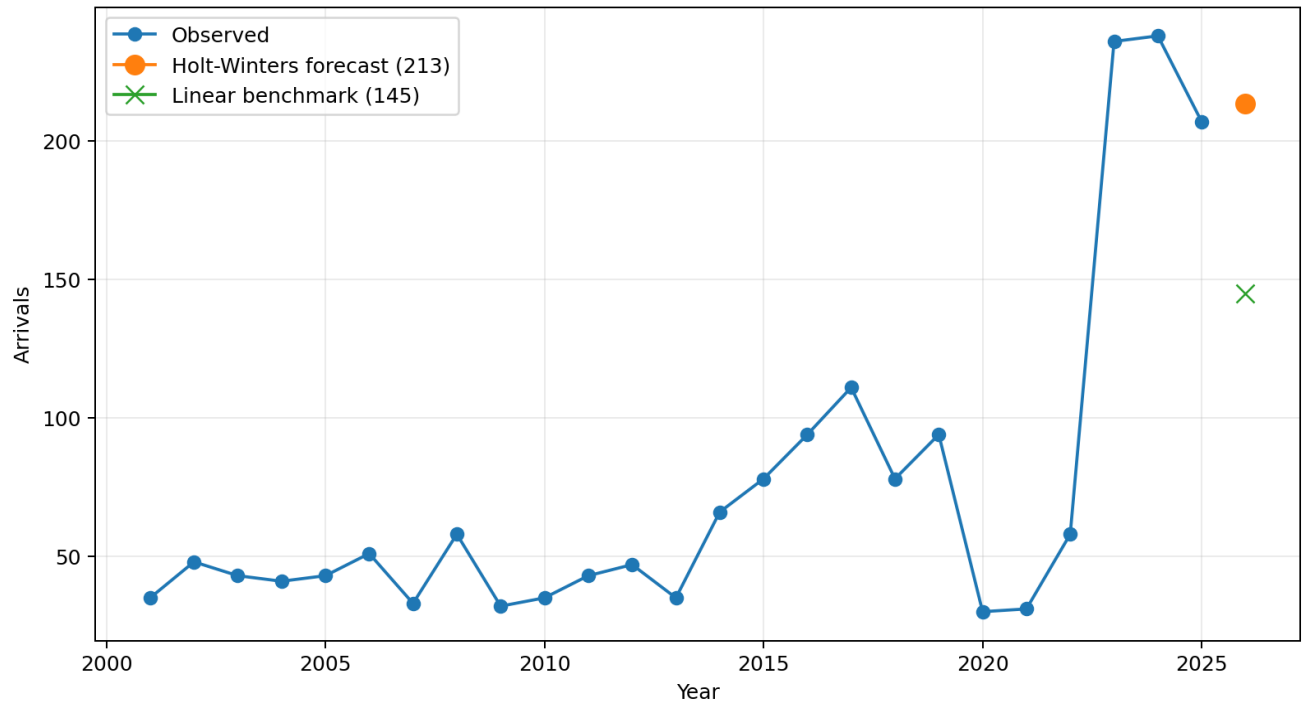


Chart 18. Nigeria 2026 forecast benchmarks



6. Ranking tables

Top West African source countries, 2001–Mar 2026

Top West African source countries, 2001–Mar 2026	Cumulative arrivals	Rank
Nigeria	1,892	1
Ghana	908	2
Mali	89	3
Guinea	82	4
Gambia	80	5
Senegal	72	6
Sierra Leone	68	7
Liberia	56	8
Burkina Faso	56	9
Niger	54	10
Benin	50	11
Togo	29	12
Cote d'Ivoire	28	13
Cabo Verde	8	14
Mauritania	5	15

Top African source countries, 2001–Mar 2026

Top African source countries, 2001–Mar 2026	Cumulative arrivals	Rank
South Africa	112,681	1
Zimbabwe	9,720	2
Egypt	2,627	3
Kenya	2,519	4
Ethiopia	2,018	5
Nigeria	1,892	6
Botswana	1,136	7
Zambia	1,051	8
Mauritius	922	9
Ghana	908	10
Tanzania	791	11
Somalia	716	12
Namibia	711	13
Uganda	657	14
Sudan	623	15

Top global source countries, 2001–Mar 2026

Top global source countries, 2001–Mar 2026	Cumulative arrivals	Rank
Asia	1,098,956	1

Oceania and Antarctica	717,274	2
Europe	526,305	3
Australia	481,239	4
United Kingdom	347,280	5
Not Stated	318,883	6
China, People's Republic of	280,317	7
India	269,157	8
The Americas	227,216	9
Africa and the Middle East	218,844	10
Philippines	147,468	11
South Africa	112,681	12
United States of America	109,453	13
Fiji	86,904	14
Korea, Republic of	81,562	15
Samoa	61,587	16
Japan	45,578	17
Canada	41,678	18
Malaysia	40,969	19
Singapore	35,426	20

Nigeria-specific ranking summary

Nigeria is 1st in West Africa cumulatively; 6th in Africa cumulatively; and approximately 79th globally among the individual country/residence categories in the supplied file. In 2025 Nigeria is 1st in West Africa, 3rd in Africa and approximately 51st globally.

7. Interpretation and policy implications

The evidence indicates that Nigerian migration to New Zealand is regionally important but globally modest. Student migration is the largest identifiable visa pathway in the cumulative Nigerian data, followed by work migration. The 2023–2025 level is substantially above the pre-2020 baseline. This makes education, skilled employment, labour demand, migration policy and post-COVID mobility key areas for further causal investigation.

The analysis should not be interpreted as a measure of the number of Nigerians living in New Zealand. Country of last permanent residence is not identical to citizenship, and this file measures migrant-arrival flows rather than population stocks or net migration.

8. Reproducibility and operational model

The accompanying Python script reproduces the data cleaning, regional aggregation, rankings, regression, correlations, hypothesis tests, visa analysis, forecasts and chart generation. It uses pandas, NumPy, SciPy, statsmodels, matplotlib and reportlab. The model includes OLS and segmented regression for inference plus a damped-trend Holt–Winters forecast as a transparent benchmark for 2026.